TEACHING SCRIPT | LESSON 13

2 Corinthians Part 1

A 50 Minute Teaching Script

BIG IDEA God displays Christ's power through weak, suffering servants who minister with integrity and reconciliation.

BEFORE CLASS Write on the board: What makes a Christian ministry credible? Under it write: How does God display Christ's power through weak and suffering servants?

0:00-5:00 Opening question prayer and transition

Good morning. We have completed 1 Corinthians, where Paul corrected a church impressed with wisdom, status, freedom, and visible gifts. Second Corinthians lets us hear the same relationship from the other side of conflict, pain, repentance, and partial reconciliation.

Our opening question is: What makes a Christian ministry credible? If needed, prompt with credentials, polished speaking, numerical growth, integrity, changed lives, endurance, and faithfulness. Then point to the controlling question: How does God display Christ's power through weak and suffering servants?

Paul's answer is surprising. Christian ministry is not credible because the servant looks invulnerable. God places Christ's treasure in fragile people so that transformed lives, endurance, truthfulness, holiness, and reconciliation point to God's power.

Let's pray. God of all comfort, give life by your Spirit, show Christ's power through our weakness, and make us faithful ambassadors of reconciliation. Amen.

5:00-12:00 Comfort integrity and restoration

Briefly set the scene. After 1 Corinthians, Paul made a painful visit and wrote a severe letter with tears. Titus later brought an encouraging report that most of the church had repented and renewed its affection for Paul. Chapters 1-7 move toward restored relationship, though serious opposition remains for chapters 10-13.

Summarize 1:3-11. God comforts us in affliction so that we can comfort others. Comfort here is strengthening and encouragement, not a promise that pain immediately disappears. Paul had been burdened beyond his own ability and learned to rely on the God who raises the dead.

Paul's changed travel plans had been used to accuse him of unreliability. He explains that he delayed another visit to spare the church further pain. His plans changed; God's promises did not. Every promise of God is Yes in Christ. Christian integrity includes honest explanation and using authority for another person's good.

The offender in 2:5-11 cannot be identified with certainty. The lesson is clear: discipline aims at repentance and restoration. Once repentance is evident, the church must forgive, comfort, and reaffirm love rather than let corrective sorrow become permanent alienation.

12:00-23:00 New covenant ministry gives life

Ask the reader to read 3:4-6 and 12-18. Paul does not claim personal brilliance or self-sufficiency. God makes servants competent for the new covenant. The Corinthians themselves are Christ's letter, written by the Spirit on human hearts.

When Paul says the letter kills but the Spirit gives life, he is not saying the Old Testament, the written Bible, or literal reading is bad. The law is holy and glorious. But commandments written outside us cannot soften rebellious hearts or supply the power to obey. The law exposes sin and therefore condemns the sinner.

The new covenant fulfills the promises of Jeremiah 31 and Ezekiel 36. God writes his will on hearts, gives his Spirit, brings righteousness rather than condemnation, and transforms his people into Christ's image.

Paul recalls Exodus 34. Moses' face reflected real glory, but it faded and was veiled. The new covenant has surpassing and enduring glory. The veil now represents hardened understanding; it is removed when a person turns to the Lord.

Avoid an anti-Jewish conclusion. Paul is a Jewish apostle interpreting Israel's Scriptures, not contrasting a bad Jewish faith with a good Gentile one. The old covenant was God's glorious gift and prepared the way for Christ. Every person depends on Christ to remove hardness and on the Spirit to transform the heart.

Here is the movement: external command exposes sin; the Spirit gives life. The veil hides glory; Christ removes it. Believers behold the Lord and are transformed from one degree of glory to another.

23:00-33:00 Treasure in jars of clay

Ask the reader to read 4:7-12 and 16-18. The treasure is the gospel knowledge of God's glory in Jesus Christ. The clay jars are ordinary, breakable messengers. Their weakness prevents anyone from mistaking the container for the treasure.

Follow Paul's contrasts: hard pressed but not crushed; perplexed but not in despair; persecuted but not abandoned; struck down but not destroyed. Faithful ministry does not avoid suffering. It discovers that suffering is not the same thing as abandonment.

The pattern of Jesus shapes the servant: carrying his death so that his life becomes visible. Paul can say death is at work in him while life is at work in those he serves. The servant spends himself; God gives life through the gospel.

Paul's light and momentary afflictions were not emotionally light. He was comparing severe present suffering with the eternal weight of glory. Never use this verse to wave away another person's pain. Use it to show why pain does not receive the final word.

The outer person wastes away, but the inner person is renewed. Faith looks beyond what is seen and temporary to what God has promised. That is why Paul can repeat: we do not lose heart.

33:00-43:00 Resurrection hope and reconciliation

Summarize 5:1-10. The earthly tent is our present mortal body. The building from God is best understood as the permanent resurrection body. Paul does not long to become a ghost; he longs to be further clothed so mortality is swallowed up by life.

Being unclothed describes the incomplete, disembodied condition between death and resurrection. Yet verse 8 assures believers that to be away from the body is to be at home with the Lord. Teach both truths: believers are consciously with Christ after death, and the ultimate Christian hope is bodily resurrection.

Every believer will appear before Christ's judgment seat. This does not cancel justification by grace or mean Christ may finally reject those who belong to him. It means our deeds, motives, and stewardship matter. Grace removes condemnation; it does not make obedience unimportant. Therefore, Paul's aim is to please Christ.

Ask the reader to read 5:14-21. Christ's love compels Paul. Christ died and rose so that his people would no longer live for themselves. In Christ there is new creation.

God reconciles enemies to himself through Christ, does not count their sins against them, and entrusts the message of reconciliation to human ambassadors. Christ, who knew no sin, bore sin and its judgment for us so that in him we receive right standing with God.

An ambassador does not invent the message or make himself the attraction. He represents the King and appeals: be reconciled to God. The astonishing point is that God entrusts this message to the same clay jars Paul has just described.

43:00-48:00 Holiness and godly sorrow

Read 6:14-7:1. The unequal yoke is broader than marriage, though marriage can be one example. Paul's contrasts focus on divided allegiance: righteousness and wickedness, light and darkness, Christ and Belial, God's temple and idols.

Paul is not commanding isolation from unbelievers. Christians still love neighbors, work with people, build friendships, and bear witness. Existing mixed marriages are not to be dissolved. Paul forbids binding participation that demands shared idolatry, divided loyalty, or compromise of Christian obedience.

What about social media, movies, and television? They are not automatically the yoke Paul describes. They are influences rather than binding partnerships. We should still ask what shapes our desires, normalizes sin, consumes our attention, or weakens obedience, but we should use the whole Bible's wisdom rather than force every media choice into this metaphor.

Chapter 7 shows the goal of correction. Godly sorrow produces repentance and a changed direction. Worldly sorrow remains centered on embarrassment, reputation, or consequences and may harden into despair. Look for fruit: earnestness, desire to make things right, and restored trust.

Ask: How can we distinguish ordinary contact with unbelievers, unhealthy influence, a binding partnership, and direct participation in idolatry? Take two or three examples without attempting to regulate every imaginable case.

48:00-50:00 Summary homework and prayer

Here is the lesson in one sentence: God gives life by his Spirit, places Christ's treasure in fragile servants, and sends reconciled sinners to minister with integrity, endurance, holiness, and open hearts.

Before next week, read 2 Corinthians 8-13. Mark what Paul teaches about generosity, spiritual authority, boasting, weakness, and the sufficiency of Christ's grace.

Let's pray. Father, thank you for the new covenant, the gift of your Spirit, and reconciliation through Christ. Keep us from trusting appearances or hiding weakness. Make us faithful clay jars, holy in our allegiance and openhearted toward the people you call us to love. Amen.